

63 Articles

Articles are short words which come before nouns to show whether they refer to a general or a specific object. There are several rules telling which article, if any, should be used.

See also:

Singular and plural nouns **69** Countable and uncountable nouns **70** Superlative adjectives **97**

63.1 THE INDEFINITE ARTICLE

The indefinite article "a" or "an" is used to talk about something in general.

I work in **a library**.

"A" is used to talk about the type of place where somebody works, not the specific building.



I work in **an office**.

"An" is used instead of "a" before words that start with a vowel.



The indefinite article is used to talk about a general thing among many of its type. The exact one is not yet known.

We are trying to buy **a house**.

The exact house they will buy is unknown.



The indefinite article is also used to show a noun belongs to a group or category.

Canada is **a very cold country**.

"Country" categorizes Canada, and "cold" describes it.



FURTHER EXAMPLES

Dogs make **a great family pet**.



The indefinite article is used in the same way for negative statements.

Jim isn't **an artist**.



Do you want to come to **an exhibition**?

The indefinite article is used in the same way for questions.



Is there **a bank** near here?

